



iQOO Hyderabad City Battle — Shortlisting Research

Objective

Collect first-hand observations from participants in the completed Bengaluru, Pune, and Chennai City Battles to improve our chances of being shortlisted for the Hyderabad offline round.



These are participant observations, not confirmed organizer rules. We should trust patterns repeated across independent replies and validate important requirements against the official submission form.

? Questions used in outreach

◆ Initial questions

1. What problem statement and track did your team submit?
2. What do you think made your application stand out?
3. From what you observed, were certain tracks or types of problems more likely to get shortlisted?



On-ground insight question

After attending the offline event and seeing all the selected teams, what “unwritten pattern” did you notice in the projects that got shortlisted? What should we clearly demonstrate in our application to qualify?



Follow-up questions

- What was common among shortlisted teams: the problem, target users, uniqueness, or on-device AI?
- How important was meaningful phone/on-device usage for shortlisting?
- Did an optional prototype or demo video noticeably improve selection chances?
- Were some tracks more competitive than others?
- Was there anything organizers or mentors emphasized onsite that was not obvious from the website?
- After seeing the selected projects, what would you change in your original application?

Participant replies

 **Nabil Shaikh**

Raw reply

It was productivity app

Clawdroid- a native android agentic app

I think it's the uniqueness and problem solving automations and on device ai scalability the more you are building on top of on device ai your project will stand out I will say go for vision ai build something around vision cause I have seen most of the projects were related to vision ai

Summary

- **Track/project:** Productivity — “Clawdroid,” a native Android agentic app.
- Credits uniqueness, problem-solving automation, and on-device AI scalability for standing out.
- Recommends building around vision AI, since most projects observed were vision-related.
- **Caution for us:** if most teams already do vision AI, a vision-only idea is not automatically differentiated — the differentiation has to come from the problem.

Tejesh Kunapareddy

Raw reply 1 — on shortlisting

I don't think certain types of problems were given more priority. From what I observed onsite, there was a diverse variety of problem statements and tracks represented. I noticed most teams were in the Open Innovation track. One common thing I observed among the shortlisted teams was that they had clearly defined their target users or target group and were addressing a specific, well-understood problem.

All the best for your submission!

Raw reply 2 — on-ground pattern

I'd say, every team got there stated their problem and target user clearly, every team that won made good and heavy use of the phone they gave, and the pattern I observed is security, most of the teams there were solving security somehow, like we were focusing on security during image sharing, the professional track winners were solving modern day toddler security, student track winners were solving identity security in live calls or whenever camera is on by blurring out person's face selectively

Summary

- No track or problem type appeared to be favoured; problem statements onsite were diverse.
- Open Innovation had the largest representation.
- Every shortlisted team had a **clearly defined target user** and a **specific, well-understood problem**.
- Every winning team made **heavy, visible use of the provided phone**.
- Security was a recurring winning theme: toddler safety (professional track) and selective face blurring for identity protection on camera/live calls (student track); this respondent's own team worked on secure image sharing.
- **Takeaway for us:** clarity of user + problem is the shortlisting filter; heavy phone usage is the winning filter.

Aditya Annamalai

Raw reply

My track was open innovation

From my perspective what I found during the event was, many people had chosen open innovation track (majority)

For submission of ur idea

Ppt is mandatory

Remaining video and partial prototype were optional but I did everything for more points

I think open innovation will help u get shortlisted more easily

And also

Usage of the phone's processor or ram or any features like camera or mic will help u get more score

The winner's of chennai city battle had used the iQOO phone's camera and did a project

So mainly usage of phone is very imp!!!

Summary

- **PPT is mandatory** for idea submission; **video and partial prototype are optional**.
- Submitted all optional material anyway to maximise points — the most actionable concrete tip so far.
- Believes Open Innovation makes shortlisting easier, but also says the majority chose it — so it is likely the most crowded track too. Treat this as opinion, not fact.
- Phone hardware usage (processor, RAM, camera, mic) directly improves scoring.
- Reports the Chennai City Battle winners built their project around the iQOO phone camera.

- **Takeaway for us:** ship PPT + video + partial prototype, and make the phone hardware central rather than incidental.

Archit Khandelwal

Raw reply

Not only there should be unique features in the application but also it should be something that users can use it daily and would want it in the mobile

Something that can ease their daily tasks

You have to demonstrate the application to the judges in a way that why your application is important to be in the phone and how wide user area it covers

Summary

- Uniqueness alone is not enough — the app must be something people would **use daily and want on their phone.**
- It should reduce friction in an everyday task.
- The pitch must explicitly answer two things: **why it belongs on a phone** and **how wide the user base is.**
- **Takeaway for us:** add an explicit “why phone” slide and a “who and how many” slide to the PPT.

Subham Sai Samal

Raw reply

hey there Sudhanshu! Subham here! before replying with anything jus letting u know that i did get selected but wasnt able to attend unfortunately because i dont have a laptop (i usually code on my pc)

Great to hear that u and ur team are actively working on FinTech :) My problem statement was EdTech,, however u may ask me whatever queries u have about the hackathon and ill try my best to answer.

Once again good luck on ur submission and looking forward to hear from u again!

Summary

- **Was shortlisted** with an EdTech problem statement but could not attend (no laptop).
- Confirms that non-trending, non-Open-Innovation tracks do get shortlisted — useful counterweight to the “Open Innovation is easier” claim.
- Did not attend, so has no onsite judging observations; value here is purely application-stage insight.
- Open to further questions — best person to ask exactly what the application form required and what he wrote.
- **Logistics reminder for us:** confirm all three of us can bring laptops; a missing laptop cost him his slot.

Other contacts (replies pending)

Garv Bansal, Prem M, Muhammad Danish, and Melvin Kannan replied and invited questions. Their detailed shortlisting insights are still pending.

Common patterns across the replies

1. **A specific user and sharply defined problem matter more than choosing a supposedly “high-acceptance” track.**
2. **The phone must be essential to the solution**, not merely a screen for a web application.
3. **Meaningful device capability usage stands out:** camera, microphone, local processing, on-device AI, or other hardware-assisted workflows.
4. **Unique but practical beats unique but vague.** Daily usefulness and a clear outcome were repeatedly emphasized.
5. **Open Innovation appears popular**, but popularity does not prove that it has a higher acceptance rate; it may also be more competitive.
6. **Security and vision AI appeared repeatedly onsite**, particularly in Chennai, but we should not copy those themes unless our problem genuinely fits them.
7. **A mandatory PPT plus optional proof**—prototype, video, or other evidence—may make an application more credible, but we still need more replies to confirm how much optional material affects shortlisting.

Working shortlisting hypothesis

Specific target user + painful, well-understood problem + differentiated solution + strong reason to exist on a phone + credible proof that the team can build it.

What we should do now

1 Select the problem before selecting the track

Evaluate each candidate idea against:

- Problem severity and frequency
- Clearly identifiable target user
- Mobile/phone necessity
- On-device AI or hardware advantage
- 30-hour build feasibility
- Demonstration quality
- Privacy, safety, and credibility

Choose FinTech only if it wins on these criteria—not simply because it is trending.

2 Make the FinTech problem narrow

Prefer a specific workflow such as:

- Detecting suspicious payment requests or scam language before payment
- Reconciling UPI receipts, invoices, and merchant records through the phone camera
- Privacy-first local spending categorization
- Accessibility-focused transaction verification
- Explaining loan/EMI/insurance terms in regional languages

Avoid generic ideas such as an “AI finance super-app,” stock predictor, basic expense tracker, or chatbot without a strong mobile differentiator.

3 Design phone-first functionality 📱

The application should clearly answer:

- Why does this need to be on a phone?
- Which phone capability is essential?
- What can run locally or through an open-source model?
- What sensitive data remains on-device?
- What complete user outcome can be demonstrated in under one minute?

4 Prepare convincing submission evidence 📊

- Strong, concise PPT
- One clear problem statement
- Specific target-user persona
- Current workflow and its failure
- Proposed phone-first workflow
- Architecture showing device usage
- Partial working prototype, if possible
- 30–60 second demo video, if permitted
- Realistic sample or synthetic data
- Clear 30-hour execution plan

5 Continue structured outreach 🤝

Ask the same core questions to at least 8–10 participants so answers remain comparable. Record the city, track, selection status, problem, phone usage, supporting submission materials, and advice. Treat a claim as a meaningful pattern when multiple independent participants repeat it.

6 Ask Subham the highest-value selection question ★

Since you were selected, what do you believe was strongest in your submitted EdTech application—the problem statement, uniqueness, phone usage,

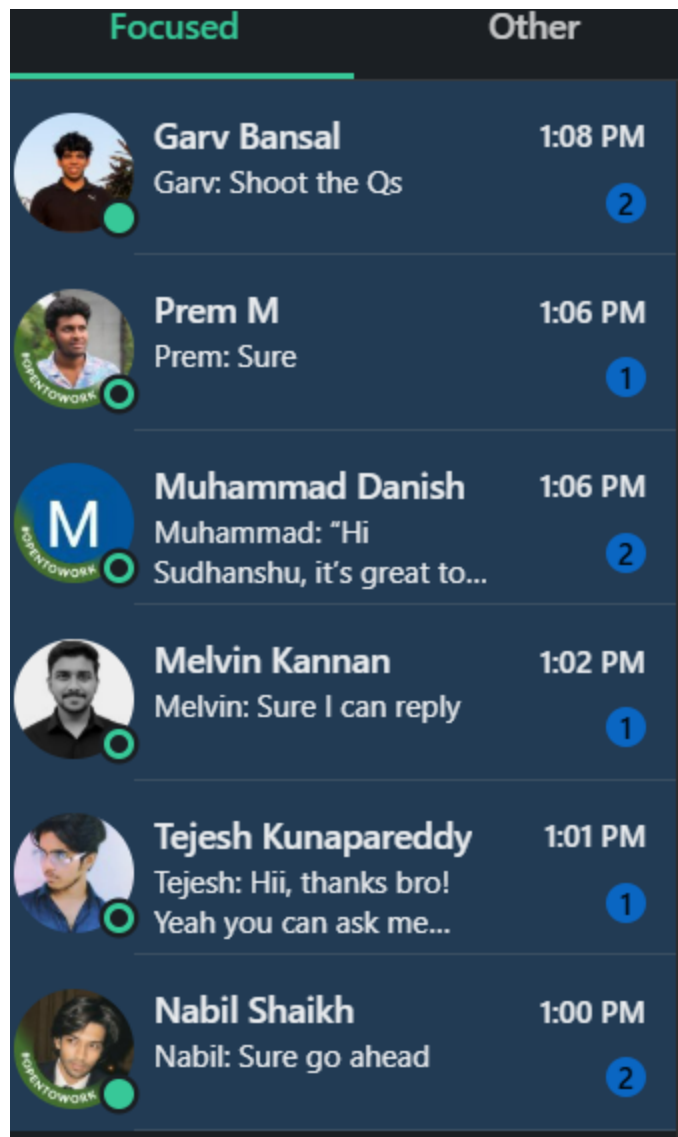
feasibility, or team profile? Did you submit any optional proof?

Application checklist

- ☐ One-sentence problem statement
- ☐ Clearly named target user
- ☐ Evidence that the problem is frequent and important
- ☐ Explanation of why existing alternatives are insufficient
- ☐ Meaningful phone/device usage
- ☐ Local or open-source AI role
- ☐ Privacy and security considerations
- ☐ Narrow MVP that can be completed in 30 hours
- ☐ Clear differentiation
- ☐ PPT completed
- ☐ Optional prototype/video prepared if accepted
- ☐ Claims kept realistic and demonstrable
- ☐ Submission proofread for clarity

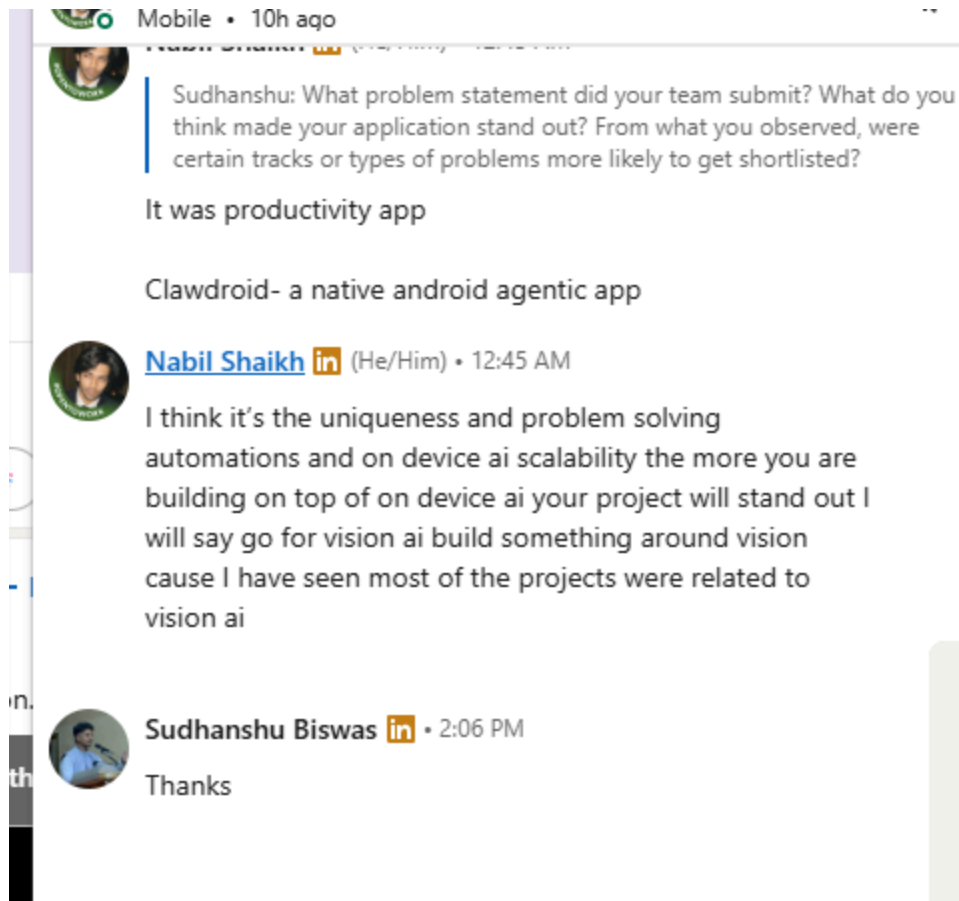
Screenshot evidence

Outreach responses overview



LinkedIn outreach responses

💬 Nabil Shaikh reply



Nabil Shaikh response

 **Tejesh Kunapareddy — initial reply**



Tejesh Kunapareddy (He/Him) • 12:24 AM

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Tejesh Kunapareddy (He/Him) • 12:34 AM

Sudhanshu: What problem statement did your team submit? What do you think made your application stand out? From what you observed, were certain tracks or types of problems more likely to get shortlisted?

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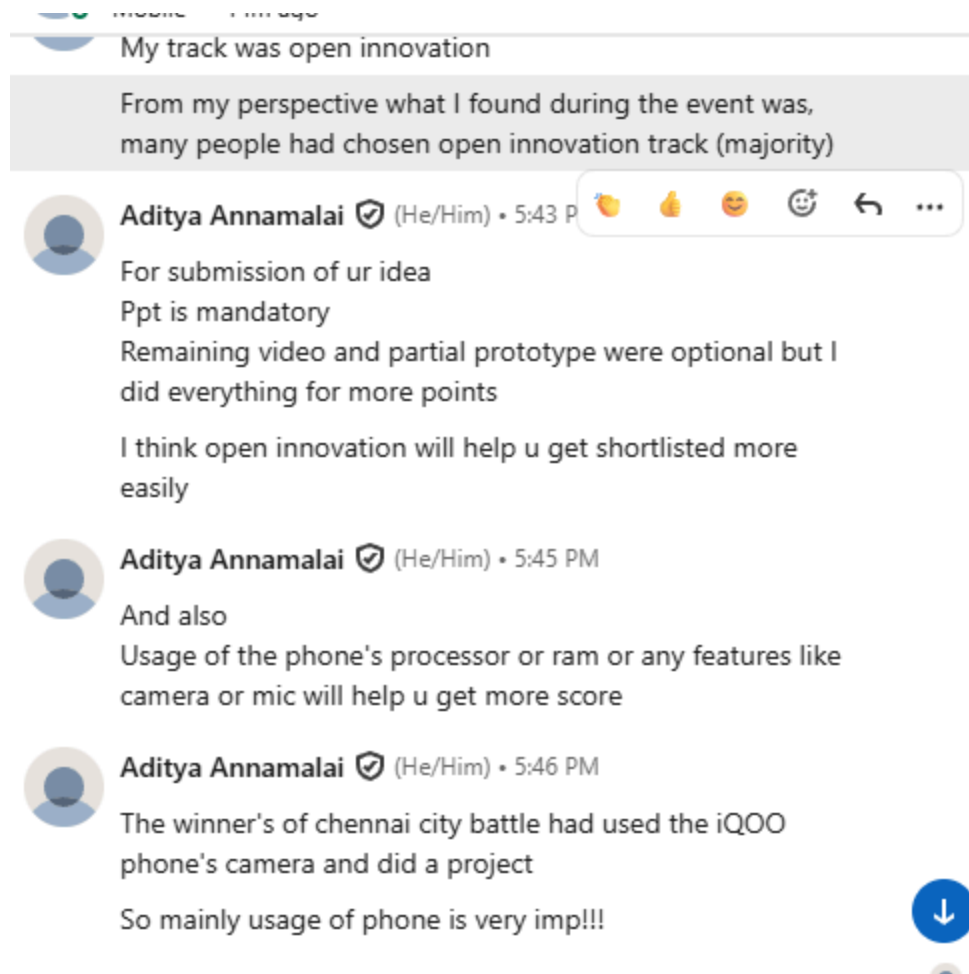
All the best for your submission!



Tejesh Kunapareddy initial response

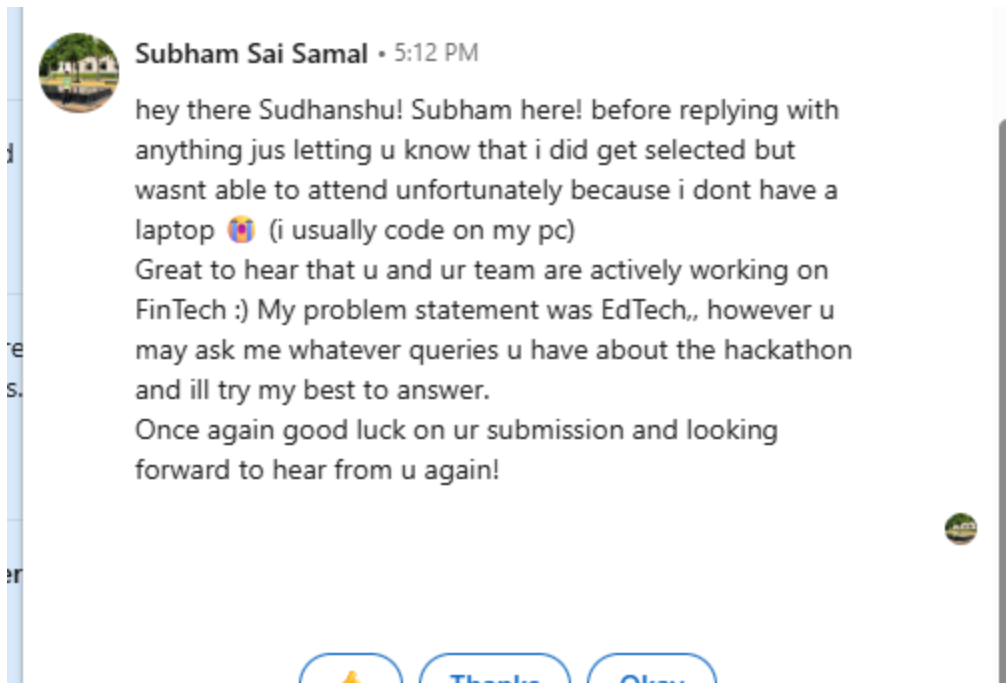


Aditya Annamalai reply



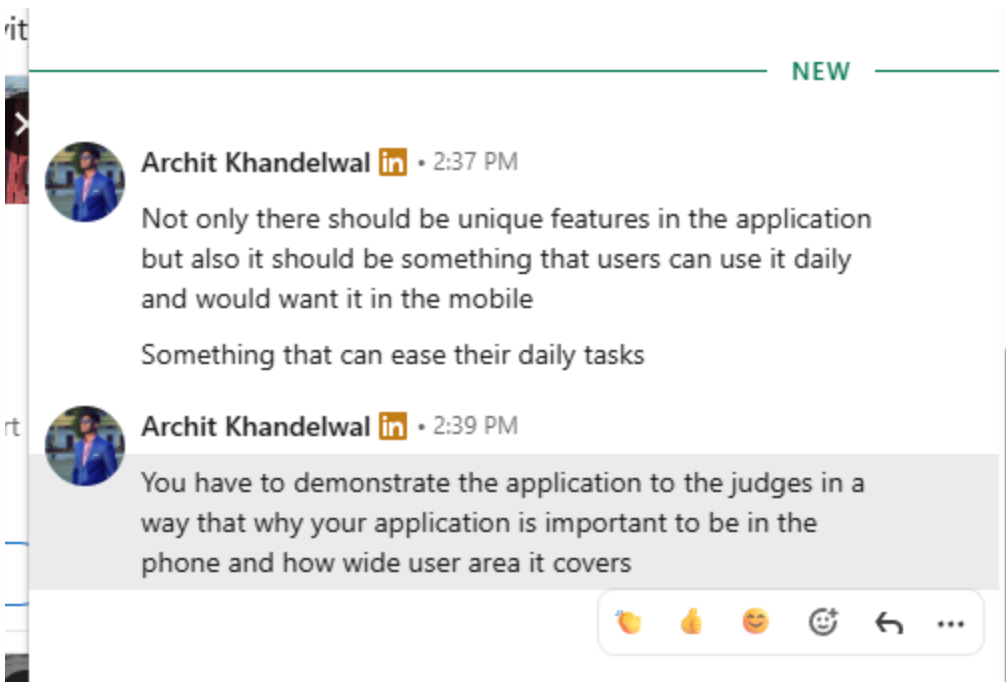
Aditya Annamalai response

Subham Sai Samal reply



Subham Sai Samal response

Archit Khandelwal reply



Arhit Khandelwal response

Tejesh Kunapareddy — on-ground pattern



Tejesh Kunapareddy (He/Him) • 2:37 PM

Sudhanshu: One final question: after attending the offline event and seeing all the selected teams, what "unwritten pattern" did you notice in the projects that got shortlisted? What should we clearly demon ...see more

I'd say, every team got there stated their problem and target user clearly, every team that won made good and heavy use of the phone they gave, and the pattern I observed is security, most of the teams there were solving security somehow, like we were focusing on security during image sharing, the professional track winners were solving modern day toddler security, student track winners were solving identity security in live calls or whenever camera is on by blurring out person's face selectively (Edited)



Tejesh Kunapareddy on-ground response